The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Mexico's army killed the leader of the **Jalisco New Generation Cartel**, the country's most notorious drug-trafficking gang. Under Nemesio Rubén Oseguera Cervantes (aka "El Mencho"), the organisation rapidly expanded; he was one of the traffickers most wanted by America's Drug Enforcement Administration. Following the military operation, burning vehicles blocked several roads in the western state of Jalisco, a tactic gangs use to stall security forces.

Ukraine accused **Hungary** and **Slovakia** of "blackmail" because they threatened to cut off supplies of electricity. That threat was a response to Ukraine's failure so far to resume transporting Russian oil to the two countries. Ukraine stopped shipments on January 27th after Russian drones attacked its pipeline infrastructure. Meanwhile, an explosion killed one woman, a police officer, and injured 25 other people in Lviv, a western Ukrainian city. The government called it a "terror attack".

Greenland declined Donald Trump's offer to send an American hospital boat with medical supplies. The Arctic island's prime minister, Jens-Frederik Nielsen, called Mr Trump's claim on Truth Social that many Greenlanders are "not being taken care of" a

“random outburst”. The defence minister of Denmark, of which Greenland is a semiautonomous constituent, said that the territory did not need more health care.

Secret Service agents shot dead a man who breached the perimeter of **Mar-a-Lago**, Mr Trump’s residence in Florida. He was not there. The suspect—a white male—had been carrying a shotgun and fuel. His motive remains unclear. The FBI is gathering evidence.

America’s Transportation Security Administration said the TSA PreCheck **airport-security programme** would remain operational. Hours earlier, the Department of Homeland Security said it would suspend it, along with the Global Entry programme. The two expedite airport security and customs procedures for millions of American citizens, permanent residents and visitors from more than 20 countries. They are threatened by a partial government shutdown.

Armed forces loyal to **Sudan’s** government said they had repelled an attack by the Rapid Support Forces on El Tina, a town on the border with Chad. The militia had earlier claimed to have captured the strategically located town, which is mainly populated by non-Arab minorities. Earlier this week the UN reported that “ethnically targeted killings” by the RSF had the “hallmarks of genocide”.

Willie Colón, a pioneering salsa musician, died at 75. The singer, songwriter and trombonist was born to Puerto Rican parents in the Bronx, New York. He mixed the musical influences from the Caribbean—salsa, mambo, jíbara and chachachá—with the jazz and funk of New York, often highlighting the problems of the Latino diaspora.

Word of the week: *Aso ebi*, a term for the matching fabrics guests wear to Nigerian weddings, meaning “cloth of the kin” in Yoruba. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

Israel’s uncertain wait over Iran

The Israeli security cabinet will meet on Sunday, a week after it was originally meant to—a postponement that indicates Israel’s leaders are not yet fully sure if America, its main ally, will attack Iran.

Israel has long viewed Iran’s nuclear programme as an unacceptable threat and has been pushing America to force Iran to put strict limits on its arsenal. Last week Donald Trump said “nothing definitive” was decided after a meeting with Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel’s prime minister, during which Iran was discussed.

Israel is preparing to join in if America does decide to attack, and readying itself for the consequences. The last time the pair struck, in June 2025, Iran retaliated by firing more than 500 missiles on Israeli cities. Most were intercepted, but enough got through to kill 28 people. Having spent years lobbying American presidents to take a harder line on Iran, Israel must now wait for Mr Trump to make up his mind.

Photograph: Getty Images

Hungary’s unusually open election

The EU’s most consequential election campaign of the year began this weekend. Viktor Orban has been Hungary’s prime minister for almost 16 years. During this time, he has repeatedly refused to support Ukraine, and courted Vladimir Putin and Donald Trump. At home, meanwhile, Mr Orban has dismantled democratic institutions and rewritten chunks of Hungary’s constitution. The European Parliament admits his regime is in effect an “electoral autocracy”.

But for the first time since 2010, Mr Orban has a formidable opponent in the election on April 12th. Peter Magyar was once prominent in Fidesz, Mr Orban’s populist-right party. He defected in 2024 and became leader of the centre-right Tisza, which is backed by young, educated, urban Hungarians. Tisza currently has a large lead in most polls. While Hungary’s gerrymandered electoral system still gives Fidesz a huge advantage—as do the handouts Mr Orban uses to tempt voters—there is a chance he might actually lose this race.

Photograph: AP

Donald Trump’s economic coercion of Cuba

The Trump administration is piling the pressure on Cuba’s communist regime. The island has suffered for decades under government mismanagement combined with American sanctions. In January the White House threatened to impose tariffs on any country that supplies it with oil. Venezuela and Mexico have halted energy imports, resulting in more blackouts and grounded flights.

Marco Rubio, the secretary of state, has long wished to see his parents’ homeland freed from 67 years of Communist Party rule. The administration is pressing for a genuine opening of Cuba’s state-dominated economy. Mr Rubio is reportedly holding secret conversations with the grandson of Raúl Castro, the brother of former leader Fidel, according to *Axios*, a news site.

For a one-party system entrenched since 1959, any regime change would be historic. Cuba’s leadership, more ideological and diffuse than Venezuela’s, knows how to play a long game. But the Trump administration is betting the economic collapse is so severe that this time that will not be possible.

Photograph: imago

Rocky relations between Japan and South Korea

Two islets in the Sea of Japan have long caused diplomatic spats. South Korea argues that Japan illegitimately annexed “Dokdo” in 1905. Meanwhile, Japan insists South Korea has illegally occupied “Takeshima” since the 1950s.

Japan’s annual “Takeshima Day”, which was instituted in 2005 and falls this Sunday, is meant to reinforce its claim. Since 2013 the government has sent only junior ministers to attend the ceremony in Shimane, the nearest prefecture. Last year Takaichi Sanae, the Japanese prime minister who recently won a landslide election victory, declared that a cabinet minister should “proudly attend”. South Korea would inevitably interpret that as a provocation.

Instead, Ms Takaichi has sailed for calmer waters. In October she agreed to “develop bilateral relations” with Lee Jae-myung, the South Korean president. The pair, both drummers, played together in January. And Ms Takaichi has rowed back her position on Takeshima, too: the same lowly level of minister is being dispatched as last year.

CHINA
RUSSIA
NORTH KOREA
Pyongyang
Dokdo/ Takeshima
Inchon
Seoul
SOUTH KOREA
Shimane
JAPAN
Tokyo
Busan
Kyoto
Fukuoka
PACIFIC OCEAN
250 km

Photograph: Reuters

No BAFTAs, please, we're British

The British Academy Film Awards are billed as the biggest night of the year for British cinema. But this Sunday's ceremony won't feature much of the country's talent. The frontrunner for the best-film prize is Paul Thomas Anderson's "One Battle After Another", an American black comedy with 14 nominations. Its closest rival is "Sinners", a yarn about vampires in Mississippi made by Ryan Coogler, another American.

Timothée Chalamet, yet another American, is expected to win best actor for his turn in "Marty Supreme", a table-tennis caper set in New York. Jessie Buckley will probably take home the best-actress trophy for playing Shakespeare's wife in "Hamnet". Though the film is technically British, it has an American-based, Chinese director (Chloé Zhao) and two Irish stars (Paul Mescal and Ms Buckley). Wunmi Mosaku, who is British-Nigerian, is nominated for her excellent supporting performance in "Sinners". But the only Briton guaranteed a big moment is Alan Cumming, the evening's host.

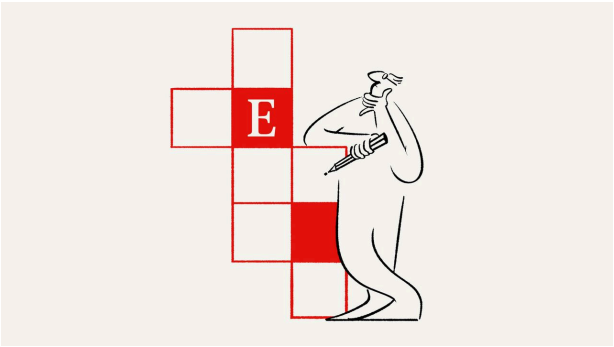

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Sounds a bit eggy for such a heavy burden (4)

2 across - Very much in German taxi(4)

3 across - America online went backwards, then north, for a borrowed sum (4)

1 down - You, SK looney, chaotically declared martial law (4,3,4)

Straight clues

1 across - Wooden bar between two animals (4)

2 across - American ride-hailing app (4)

3 across - Something to pay back (4)

1 down - Former South Korean president banged up for life (4,3,4)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of the week’s quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week’s quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Gavin Meacham, Canberra, Australia

Kate Marshall, Toronto, Canada

Vittorio Ferrario, Geneva, Switzerland

They all gave the correct answers of: scarlet (the disease is scarlet fever), hounds, Ginger Baker, Hudson’s Bay company and Thomas Watson (“Mr Watson, come here, I want to see you,” Bell said). The theme is Sherlock Holmes who featured in the stories “A Study in Scarlet” and “The Hound of the Baskervilles”, and lived in Baker Street with a housekeeper Mrs Hudson and friend Dr Watson.

The questions were:

Monday: What colour, traditionally worn by a cardinal, is also associated with a childhood disease?

Tuesday: Grey, blood and basset are words that precede the name of what type of dog?

Wednesday: Which famous drummer was one of the founder members of the rock group Cream?

Thursday: Which Canadian business, originally founded in 1670 and noted for its department stores, was finally liquidated in 2025?

Friday: When Alexander Graham Bell made the first telephone call, who did he call?

This is the world you have made yourself, now you have to live in it.

Nina Simone